

MYSTIQUE OF THE LONE STAR

By Jim Bishop

When you hear the words "Lone Star" what do they bring to mind? Chances are it'll be one of two things. To some folks "Lone Star" means "Texas". To others, it makes them think of a popular beer which should rightfully be drunk only from longneck bottles. A beer which is claimed by its makers to be "The National Beer of Texas". Television commercials would have us believe that it is the one liquid refreshment which giant armadillos will kill for.

Let's face it though. As nice as a cold beer may be on a hot Texas day, we (that is, the State of Texas) were here a long time before they were. Now don't get me wrong, I'm not knocking them. All the money they've spent over the years promoting that name has just added to the free publicity for TEXAS. The Lone Star State. You know, you can't go into any cafe or beer joint in the southwestern U.S. that doesn't have one of those purty little red, white, and blue neon signs buzzing at you saying "Lone Star Beer". It'll be there, hanging behind the bar or on the wall above the plastic and chrome booths.

Hot dang, there's even a cafe-beer joint-bar up in THE BIG CITY (New York that is) called the Lone Star Cafe. This place has become one of the most popular watering holes in the whole darn town. I hear you have to make reservations in advance for a bottle of beer (Lone Star, of course). This bar has become a favorite place for displaced Texans who have either been sent up there by their corporations for punishment, or they are there voluntarily, God forbid, because they were dumb enough to think that the only place you can make it B-I-G is in the B-I-G CITY. What really galls me though is to realize that two yankees started that place and are responsible for it's success. Now doesn't that just take the rag off the bush. How successful do you think that place would have been if they would have named it "The Corn Husker Bar" ? Or something like "The Golden State Bar" No way, Jose.

Personally, I would like to think that most folks associate the words "Lone Star" with the State of Texas. I started hearing about Texas, long before I got to geography in school. My Grandpa lived with us when I was a kid growing up in Oklahoma. He had been a Texas cowwaddie in his younger days and had made lots of cattle drives from Texas up to Abilene, Kansas. Boy, the stories that old man used to tell me. All of my younger years were filled with stories from books and magazines, and thrilling cowboy movies about that big piece of real estate which was on the other side of the

Red River from Oklahoma. It was called TEXAS. The name carried magic in its very sound. I visited here a number of times, coming to Galveston with my parents on vacation, or visiting my Aunt Edith in Dallas. I remember standing in boyish awe at the sights and sounds of the Texas Centennial Exposition in 1936. Years later, when I was in college at the University of Oklahoma, I went to one O.U.-Texas football game at the Cotton Bowl; drew my combat pay and refused to go back for any future contests.

The mystique that has always surrounded Texas.....

"What's that. Billy Bob? No. Mystique is not a tree that grows in Texas. That's a mesquite". Now where was I?

Oh yes.

The mystique that has always surrounded Texas was effectively brought to my attention one time back during WWII when I was in the U.S. Infantry in England waiting to go to Germany and whup up on Hitler. The English people loved the "Yanks" as they wanted to call all of us. Being called yanks didn't set to well with the southerners but we just grinned and took it. We couldn't, after all, insult our hosts, could we?

Whenever American soldiers came into contact with the English, they would always want to know what state we were from. After introductions, the first matter to be cleared in the conversation was always THE QUESTION.

"Where are you from in the states, Yank?"

At first my reply was always, "Oklahoma." That usually drew such non-committal answers as,

"Jolly good." or, "I say, that's where the redskins are isn't it?" Some would smile quiscally and admit they had no earthly idea where Qklahoma was located, except that it was "someplace in the west".

One time when someone asked me where I was from, I decided I would say Texas. People seemed to be impressed with Texans. This wouldn't be stretching a point too far since I had just spent over a year training there in the Army, I had married a girl from Texas, and IF I got back from the war, that was where we were going to live, love, and raise our family. So I became a Texan.

The reaction was strong, positive, and instantaneous.

"TEXAS."

"Oh I say. That's quite a place, that. You've the largest state of them all, righto?" I then heard all about cowboys and indians, outlaws, the Alamo, stagecoaches, deserts, cactus, sagebrush, tumbleweeds, mountains, the Rio Grande River, and even some things that I didn't know myself about Texas. Before the evening was over several of my new found British friends insisted on calling me "Tex". This seemed to give them pleasure and I was too embarassed to object. I just did a Gary Cooper impression, said, "Aw shucks" and looked down modestly at my combat boots.

The bar maid in the little pub where all this took place even
drew me a beer "on the house " at the request of her father
who ran the pub. If that doesn't say something for the power
and impact of the name "TEXAS" then you just don't know
British pub keepers.